

Push Against Mail Ballot Leaves Voters Confused

Some May Give Up. That May Be the Point.

This article is by **Anna Griffin, Rebecca Fairley Raney, Kendal Asbury and David Iversen.**

President Trump’s legal and rhetorical assault on voting by mail — and the flurry of contradictory court decisions around it — has left voters confused and local officials scrambling just eight weeks before November’s critical midterm elections.

The contortions have county registrars dusting off Election Day contingency plans developed for natural disasters like floods and wildfires. They have struggled to make it through planning meetings before the latest version of the rules changes, and many are encouraging voters to avoid the U.S. Postal Service all together.

Among voters, confusion abounds.

“I don’t trust mail-in or in-person, to be honest with you,” said Lori Woo, a 53-year-old teacher from Wildomar, Calif. She has voted both in person and by mail and now wonders whether any of her votes were counted.

Arizona officials have been encouraging voters like Antonio Bergier, an 83-year-old retired geologist, to drop off ballots in person. But he said he didn’t know whether his hometown, Patagonia, or his county, Santa Cruz, had ballot drop boxes — nor would he use them anyway.

Mail, he said, is “the only way they’re getting my vote this year.”

Twenty states are set to mail

ballots to voters by Sept. 19, starting with North Carolina, which began sending out absentee ballots on Friday.

“We plan to proceed as planned,” Sam Hayes, the director of North Carolina’s elections board, said at a news conference on Thursday.

But even election officials were reluctant to issue reassuring encomiums.

“I wish that I could tell my constituents to not worry, and I can’t,” said Gabriella Cázares-Kelly, who oversees elections in Pima County, Ariz., where 85 percent of ballots are delivered early or by mail.

In many places with mail-in voting, the bulk of ballots aren’t scheduled to go out for another month. But the response has already begun.

In Los Angeles County, one of the largest voting districts in the nation, elections officers have responded to the uncertainty with ballot distribution and collection plans that were deployed after the devastating Eaton and Palisades wildfires of 2025. Ideas include expanding in-person options like pop-up voting sites, places where people could request and fill out ballots.

“If this is a problem, let’s make it an administrative problem, not a voter problem,” said Dean Logan, the Los Angeles County registrar. “We do not want voters to be deterred from voting.”

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NEWS ANALYSIS

In Clancy Trial, Her Lawyer Put Empathy First

By **RICHARD FAUSSET**

Kevin Reddington, a veteran trial lawyer, kicked off the defense of his client earlier this summer with an audacious assertion, given that his client is Lindsay Clancy, the Massachusetts nurse who had admitted to strangling her three young children.

“This,” Mr. Reddington told 12 jurors in his opening remarks, “is not a righteous prosecution.”

Eleven of those jurors voted not to convict Ms. Clancy, 36, who claimed she was suffering from postpartum psychosis at the time of the killings. With one holdout juror, the judge declared a mistrial, leaving a question mark hovering over a murder case that set off a global conversation about the mental health burdens of motherhood, and long-held questions about the essential fairness of the insanity defense.

A retrial is possible. But for now, the mistrial must be considered a victory for Mr. Reddington, one that allows his client to return, for the time being at least, to a state-run psychiatric hospital rather than a prison cell.

But if Mr. Reddington is to be believed, it will not register as a win for Ms. Clancy. During the trial, he described her as a mother well aware of what she had done to her children and “living her own hell.”

Such statements by Mr. Reddington were part of a defense strategy that acknowledged Ms. Clancy’s dark actions but emphasized her mental health problems and the missteps of the medical establishment as she sought help. In the wake of the six-week trial, a number of legal experts said that Mr. Reddington, 75, had masterfully pulled off an astonishingly difficult courtroom as-

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ASANKA BRENDON RATNAYAKE FOR THE N.Y.T.

Entries in the Official Great Aussie Meat Pie Competition.

Best Meat Pie? Tensions Swell, As Do Judges.

By **LAURA CHUNG**

MELBOURNE, Australia — Brendan Carter took two bites of the pie in front of him and made a face. “Too salty,” he said and placed it into the box at his feet. Around him, judges probed, sniffed and chomped into Australia’s most beloved snack: the meat pie.

The meat pie is consumed year-round in Australia, on cold winter mornings after a sports game or at country town pit stops on long summer road trips. Australians consume an estimated 270 million meat pies a year, usually smothered in ketchup and served piping hot. It is an egalitarian snack, with filling known for spilling down the fronts of business shirts, team uniforms or favorite T-shirts.

But once a year, those who know meat pies even better than the average Australian gather to decide which pastry-and-filling deserves to be set apart from the others and recognized for its excellence.

Over four days, 16 judges tested 1,800 single-portion pies and sausage rolls made by the country’s bakers, chefs, pastry cooks and butchers at the Official Great Aussie Meat Pie Competition, held last week at the Fine Food Australia trade fair in Melbourne.

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DAVID GUTTENFELDER/THE NEW YORK TIMES

A confrontation with protesters in Minneapolis on Jan. 24, the day federal agents fatally shot Alex Pretti, a 37-year-old resident.

Agency Skipped Basic Checks to Meet Trump’s Hiring Surge, Whistle-Blower Says

This article is by **Alexandra Berzon, Katie Benner and Hamed Aleaziz.**

In the wake of a hiring surge last summer, an official in charge of evaluating new recruits to U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement issued a dire warning.

The Trump administration, he wrote in a memo, was cutting corners, violating the law and fast-tracking unqualified, “improperly vetted” candidates into ICE’s

ranks, part of a dangerous move that exposed the agency — and its law enforcement operations — to “grave national security risks.”

Citing an “unprecedented lowering of standards,” the career ICE official said that “systemic breakdowns” had allowed applicants to receive job offers before they had passed basic fingerprint, identity or credit checks in a preliminary vetting process. Political appointees had unjustly skirted background investigations and received national security eligibility.

The official, a unit chief who directly oversaw more than 100 employees who evaluated thousands of ICE applicants, was so troubled by what he saw that he outlined these concerns not to his superiors, but in a formal whistle-blower complaint to the Office of Inspector General in the Department of Homeland Security.

In the complaint, he asked for an independent, outside investigation into the matter. He was later interviewed twice by officials with the inspector general’s office

and his concerns have become part of an ongoing audit into vetting practices.

The complaint, which has not been previously reported, underscores the rising worries about the suitability — as well as the tactics — of scores of agents who have been rapidly deployed across the country within the last year. It also outlines the extent to which ICE weakened its standards, and points to dissension among the upper reaches of the

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ROMAN PILIPEY/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

Ukraine officials awaiting the arrival of a U.S. contingent under a sign reading “PEACE EXPRESS.”

Trump Envoys Travel to Kyiv for the First Time

By **CASSANDRA VINOGRAD and ANDREW E. KRAMER**

KYIV, Ukraine — President Trump’s envoys, Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, met with officials in Ukraine on Sunday in their first trip to the country and the second stop on a diplomatic tour aimed at reviving efforts to end the war between Ukraine and Russia.

Mr. Witkoff and Mr. Kushner came straight from Moscow, where they spent several hours on Saturday with Vladimir V. Putin,

Few Expecting Visit to Bring Breakthrough

the Russian president. Arriving in Kyiv by train, they alighted on a platform bearing a sign that read, “PEACE EXPRESS,” and then were taken by motorcade to meet President Volodymyr Zelensky.

The men discussed what were later said to include “new ideas,” though details were scant.

Mr. Witkoff and Mr. Kushner

have traveled to Moscow several times but never before visited Kyiv, despite multiple official invitations.

“We have been waiting for Steve and Jared, Witkoff and Kushner, for a long time,” Mr. Zelensky told reporters before greeting the two with hugs on Sophia Square, where photos of fallen soldiers formed a somber backdrop.

The men met for about three hours. In the gilded halls of Marinsky Palace, they briefly addressed journalists afterward —

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Deadly Limbo In Fitful Battle Over Strait Oil

By **PETER EAVIS and JENNY GROSS**

For months the U.S. military has sought to protect tankers from Iranian attacks as they carry Persian Gulf oil through the Strait of Hormuz.

But late last month, a Saudi vessel trying to go through the strait was struck close to Oman’s coast, killing two of its crew members. Two other sailors died in attacks in August last month, making it the deadliest month in the strait for merchant seamen since March. At least 23 ships were hit in the waterway in July and August. On Saturday, the United States struck three Iranian oil tankers in retaliation for what it said were unprovoked attempts by Iran to attack two U.S. warships.

After more than six months of war, analysts said the strait remained in a lethal stalemate.

“The strait is neither fully closed nor fully opened,” said Eugene Gholz, an associate professor of political science at the University of Notre Dame and an expert on conflict in the waterway. “Iran can’t close it completely, and the U.S. can’t open it completely.”

The U.S. tanker protection effort, which involves intercepting Iranian drones and missiles before they hit ships, has helped get millions of barrels of oil out of the Persian Gulf each day and provided a measure of relief to oil markets.

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Heavy Cost of Iran War

First Lt. Tyler James Feehan, one of 18 soldiers killed, was at a base in Jordan when enemy missiles struck. PAGE A9

5 Dead in Cargo Plane Crash

Flights were halted for hours at Miami International Airport after an Amazon plane overran its landing. PAGE A13

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Deported, Broke and Stranded

Hundreds have been sent back to Haiti in recent weeks, and some say they have been left with no protection from gangs and no place to go. PAGE A8

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Error-Aided Nobel Laureate

Hideki Shirakawa, 90, a chemist, helped to discover electricity-conducting plastics, largely by accident. PAGE B7

A Pioneer in Transplants

Dr. Paul S. Russell, over 70 years, led the way in turning new findings into better results. He was 101. PAGE B6



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Beef Buyers and Farmers Irked

New initiatives to appease ranchers after President Trump said he’d increase imports aren’t a quick fix. PAGE B1

Exit Reflects Pivot at Fox News

Maria Bartiromo’s departure reveals the network’s cautious approach, especially with election deniers. PAGE B1

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Train Data That Swings

Joshua Wolk, a web designer, has created a site where Amtrak’s routes have been turned into jazz instruments playing songs that are based on trains’ real-time movements. PAGE C1

Arts Lead a Town’s Way Back

In Lansing, N.C., a center teaching so-called Old World skills like fiber arts and clay throwing provides community and a bridge between the area’s past and future. PAGE C1

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Kristin Kobes Du Mez

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Putting In the Needed Work

After failing to defend her U.S. Open singles title in 2024, Coco Gauff overhauled her serve and forehand. She is now on a roll again. PAGE D1



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